

HOLLYWOOD CALLING

A strong domestic market beckons as India becomes the American studios' must-go-to destination for local language movies. The \$100-million investment may be a blip on the Indian radar right now, but it looks set to grow.

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Alain Ducasse at The Dorchester in London's tony Park Lane is the kind of pricey restaurant dealmakers go to when they want to shake hands on a really big one. That's where Fox Filmed Entertainment Co-Chairman Jim Gianopulos, Fox STAR Studios India CEO Vijay Singh, and producer-director Vipul Shah met earlier this month before announcing to the media Fox Star Studio's first of a series of co-production and acquisition partnerships in Bollywood. At about \$25 million for two films over the next 18 months, it's small change for a Hollywood studio whose parent company made \$28.7 billion in revenue last year. But a small step for Rupert Murdoch's News Corp is a giant leap in the ongoing love affair between an embattled Hollywood where revenues are plateauing and a cash-rich Bollywood with a growing domestic market.

Part of the increased interest from Hollywood is because despite efforts to dub their films in Hindi, running a

blitzkrieg marketing them, and even going big with the release (for instance Sony is releasing over 600 prints of the new Bond film, *Quantum of Solace*), foreign movie revenues have not grown. As Siddharth Roy Kapur, CEO of UTV Motion Pictures, puts it, "They've realised they need to be a long-term player here and build relationships." So though Murdoch may have been the prime mover in the West's chalo India strategy, having bought Star TV in 1993 from Hong Kong billionaire Li Ka-Shing, he is not the only media mogul to look east. American majors are not new to Indian

A LONG HAUL:
Akshay Kumar
(left) and
Deepika
Padukone in
*Chandni Chowk
To China*



Warner Bros will release its first major co-production in India, **CHANDNI CHOWK TO CHINA**, for which it will hold global rights. It has also signed a multi-picture deal with Soundarya Rajnikanth's **OCHER STUDIOS**.

